

# The Void of Nagarjunakonda

## (c. 220–c. 320 CE)

On the morning of 21 February 1920, a Telugu schoolteacher, S. Venkataramayya, from an Andhra village, Macherla, set out on an excursion with a few other villagers. He had received word from ‘some cowherds about the existence of stone pillars and mounds of brick overgrown by jungle’.[1]

After going about 20 km west, they climbed the rocky Nallamalai Range where seven hills enclosed a 24 sq. km valley except on the north and west, where it was flanked by the mighty Krishna River. The river was then almost 1 km wide while still over 200 km from the Bay of Bengal.

The valley had ‘an evil reputation for malaria’, but they descended and entered its thorny jungle, which had a few ‘gazelle, peafowl and sandgrouse’ as well as venomous cobras, vipers and pythons. The valley was then home to a few Telugu Hindus and the Lambadis, a ‘picturesque gypsy tribe’ of pastoralists and cultivators. They lived in Pullareddiguddem, a hamlet of mud huts and thatched roofs. The hamlet had a chief called Reddi, who had a large herd of cattle, the best house and ‘whose word [was] law in all local matters’.

The valley also had the Chenchus, an Adivasi tribe of hunter-gatherers living off small game, collecting honey, roots and firewood. According to archaeologist A.H. Longhurst, who worked here from 1927–31, ‘The